

CITY ON A HILL — design draft

A small turn-based strategy game. Web app. Rough draft, plain language.

The one-line version

You have four pieces on a small board. Darkness walks in from the edges. Keep the lamp lit and get light down to the houses.

You do **not** win by killing everything.

The board

7 across, 7 down. 49 squares. Columns are letters A-G. Rows are numbers 1-7.

	A	B	C	D	E	F	G	
1								
2								
3								
4				△				△ = temple + lamp
5								
6								
7				□	□	□		□ = houses

Temple is always **D4**, dead centre. Houses are always **C7, D7, E7**.

Why 7 and not 8: an odd number gives you a true middle square. On an 8×8 board the temple sits between four squares and everything gets awkward.

Light

The temple lights every square within **2 steps** of it. That's the box from B2 to F6.

	A	B	C	D	E	F	G	
1	.	.	.	.	.	.	.	
2	.	■	■	■	■	■	.	
3	.	■	■	■	■	■	.	
4	.	■	■	△	■	■	.	
5	.	■	■	■	■	■	.	
6	.	■	■	■	■	■	.	
7	.	.	□	□	□	.	.	<-- houses are DARK

The houses are outside the light. Getting light to them is the goal.

You do that by building a **cornerstone** further down the board. A cornerstone lights 2 steps around itself too.

Build one at D6 and the light joins up:

	A	B	C	D	E	F	G	
1	.	.	.	.	.	.	.	
2	.	█	█	█	█	█	.	
3	.	█	█	█	█	█	.	
4	.	█	█	△	█	█	.	
5	.	█	█	█	█	█	.	
6	.	█	█	◆	█	█	.	◆ = cornerstone
7	.	.	█	█	█	.	.	<-- houses now LIT

Darkness

Threats walk in from the edge squares. One square per turn. They head for the temple.

If a threat is next to the temple at the end of its move, it hits the temple.

Three hits and you lose.

Seeing the future

This is the main idea of the game.

There is a second view of the board. Press a key to flip to it. It shows where threats **will** appear, two turns before they do.

Normal view — turn 1, board is empty:

	A	B	C	D	E	F	G	
1	.	.	.	.	.	.	.	
2	.	.	.	.	.	.	.	
3	.	.	.	.	.	.	.	
4	.	.	.	△	.	.	.	
5	.	.	.	.	.	.	.	
6	.	.	.	.	.	.	.	
7	.	.	□	□	□	.	.	

Future view — same turn, flipped:

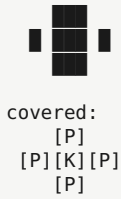
	A	B	C	D	E	F	G	
1	.	.	.	.	.	.	?	
2	.	.	.	.	.	[2]		<-- arrives turn 3
3	.	.	.	.	.	.	.	
4	[2]	.	.	△	.	.	.	<-- arrives turn 3
5	.	.	.	.	.	.	.	
6	.	.	.	.	.	.	.	
7	.	.	□	□	□	.	.	

So you always know what's coming. The difficulty isn't surprise — it's that you never have enough pieces to cover everything you can see.

Later levels only show **one** turn ahead.

Your four pieces

The Protector — big slow knight



Moves 1 square per turn.
Cannot attack. Ever.

Covers his square + the 4 squares
beside him. Threats CANNOT walk
into a covered square. They have
to go around.

Good if you know where trouble is coming. Useless if you guessed wrong — he can't get there in time.

The Destroyer — winged, flies anywhere

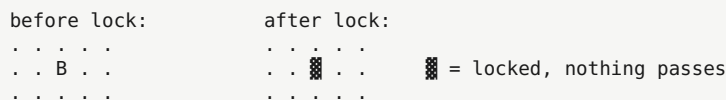
Removes any threat on the board, instantly, from any distance.

Only 3 uses per level.

And there is a catch. See below.

The Binder — heavy rock

Moves 1 square per turn. His action is to **lock** the square he's on.



Nothing crosses a locked square — not threats, **not your own pieces either**. And the Binder is stuck there until he spends a turn unlocking.

So locking always costs you something too.

The Looser — a swarm of red fish

Moves 3 squares per turn. Fast.

His action unlocks a locked square, or frees a trapped piece.

He dies in one hit. But while he's alive he blocks a square, so a threat has to spend a turn killing him instead of advancing.

Sometimes he's worth more dead in the right square than alive in the wrong one.

The catch with the Destroyer

The game counts, quietly, how often you use the Destroyer when you didn't have to.

Nothing is said. No warning. No red flash.

Do it too often and from the next level he **stops waiting for orders**. At the start of each enemy turn he flies off and destroys something himself, spending a charge you might have needed.

You can't undo it. You just play the rest of the game around a piece you don't fully control.

That's the point of the whole game: the easy answer used too often becomes a habit, and habits act without you.

Building

A piece standing on an empty square can spend its turn building.

Some squares have bad soil. You can see this if you brought **Knowledge**; otherwise you find out by trying.

- Bad soil → spend 1 turn preparing it
- Then 1 turn to plant
- Then it finishes 2 turns later

While it's being built the square is defenceless.

So you build when the board is quiet, not when you need it.

Pick one helper per level

Before the level starts you choose **one** of seven. Only one.

Helper	What it does
Counsel	See 1 extra turn into the future
Might	Protector covers a wider area
Knowledge	Soil quality visible from the start
Understanding	You see what type each threat is before it lands
Fear of the Lord	Threats pause 1 turn when entering your light
Wisdom	One extra action, once per level
Spirit of the Lord	A small amount of all of the above

The same board plays completely differently depending on which one you brought. That's what makes it worth replaying.

Build the first three for v1. The rest later.

Win / lose

Win: survive the level's turn count AND all three houses are lit. **Lose:** temple takes 3 hits.

A full level, turn by turn

Level 1. Eight turns. Helper: **Counsel**.

Start:

	A	B	C	D	E	F	G	
1	.	.	.	.	.	.	.	
2	.	.	.	.	.	.	.	
3	.	.	.	D	.	.	.	D = Destroyer
4	.	.	B	△	L	.	.	B = Binder L = Looser
5	.	.	.	P	.	.	.	P = Protector
6	.	.	.	.	.	.	.	
7	.	.	□	□	□	.	.	

Turn 1. Future view shows two threats arriving turn 3 — at A4 and G2. Board is empty and calm.

Player checks D6, where a cornerstone would light the houses. Soil is bad.

→ *Spends the whole turn preparing soil at D6.* Nothing visible happens.

This is the hardest move in the game and it's the first one.

Turn 2. Future view now shows a third threat, turn 4, at D1 — straight line to the temple.

Three threats. Four pieces. The sums start.

→ *Binder walks C4 → B4.* B4 is the narrow point on the west route.

Turn 3. Threats appear at A4 and G2, exactly as shown.

	A	B	C	D	E	F	G	
1	.	.	.	.	.	.	.	
2	.	.	.	.	.	.	X	X = threat
3	.	.	.	D	.	.	.	
4	X	⊠	.	△	L	.	.	⊠ = Binder, locked
5	.	.	.	.	P	.	.	
6	.	.	.	.	.	.	.	
7	.	.	□	□	□	.	.	

→ *Binder locks B4.* The west threat is now stuck grinding against it. → *Protector D5 → E5,* covering the east side.

Cost: the Binder is stuck, and the player's own pieces can't cross B4 either.

Turn 4. East threat moves G2 → F3. Third threat appears at D1.

The player wants to use the Destroyer. D1 is a straight line to the temple.

→ *They don't.* Looser moves E4 → D2, standing in the way. He'll die there and cost the threat a turn.

Good play. Not obvious.

Turn 5. Looser dies. North threat now at D2. East threat at E3, stuck against the Protector's cover.

→ *Plants the cornerstone at D6.* Soil is ready so it takes. Nothing is near D6, so this is the moment.

Turn 6. Cornerstone half built. North threat at D3 — one square from the temple.

Player panics slightly.

→ *Destroyer on D3.* Gone.

It worked. But the Binder could have been released and walked over, and the Protector could have shifted one square. **The game makes a note.**

Turn 7. East threat goes around the Protector, E3 → E2.

→ *Destroyer again.* **Second note.**

The player sees nothing. No counter on screen.

Turn 8. Cornerstone finishes. Light joins up. Houses lit. Lamp never went out.

Level complete.

End screen — the lit map, the glowing houses, no score. One line at the bottom:

Your Destroyer acted twice where another would have served.

That's all it says.

What that level taught, without a single tutorial box

- Turn 1 — spending a turn on nothing is sometimes right
 - Turns 2-3 — the Binder solves problems by giving up his own freedom
 - Turn 4 — a piece can be worth more dead in the right square
 - Turn 5 — build when it's quiet, not when you need it
 - Turns 6-7 — the easy button is always there, and that's the problem
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Look and feel

Grungy pixel art. Worn, dim, institutional. Not cosy, not cute.

Think a map table in a room with one working bulb.

- 24 colours maximum, locked palette
 - Muted greens, greys, rust, nicotine yellow
 - The **only** bright colour on screen is the lamp
 - As the lamp takes hits, the whole screen gets dimmer
 - Almost nothing animates. Pieces slide. Darkness creeps. That's it.
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Scope

v1: 1 region, 6 levels, 4 pieces, 3 helpers, no meta-progression. Roughly 3 months, one developer.

Later: remaining 4 helpers, the cube (permanent upgrades between levels), more regions.

Test this on paper first

Before any code is written: draw the 7×7 grid, cut out four counters, write the level 1 spawn schedule on a card, and play it by hand for an afternoon.

If knowing what's coming two turns early doesn't create interesting choices on paper, no amount of code will fix it.